

American Political Divides and Great Debates

[84-309] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: August 23, 2026

Professor **Jonathan Cervas**

Office: Posner Hall 374

Email: cervas@cmu.edu

Location: Scaife Hall 234

Time: Tuesday & Thursday 2:00p-3:20p Eastern

Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (arrange via email)

CMU Academic Calendar

TA: **Zakareya Hamed**

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Office Hours: arrange via email

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**

Course Relevance: DC: Perspectives on Justice and Injustice

Learning Resources: All resources will be provided via Canvas

Prerequisites: NONE

August

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
						1
2	3	4	5	6	7	8
9	10	11	12	13	14	15
16	17	18	19	20	21	22
23	24	25	26	27	28	29
30	31					

September

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
		1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16	17	18	19
20	21	22	23	24	25	26
27	28	29	30			

October

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
				1	2	3
4	5	6	7	8	9	10
11	12	13	14	15	16	17
18	19	20	21	22	23	24
25	26	27	28	29	30	31

November

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9	10	11	12	13	14
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30					

December

S	M	T	W	T	F	S
		1	2	3	4	5
6	7	8	9	10	11	12
13	14	15	16	17	18	19
20	21	22	23	24	25	26
27	28	29	30	31		

☒ in person

☒ remote

☐ no class

Why are Americans so divided — and is the premise even true? We spend a month on what political science actually knows, then the semester is yours: student teams pick the topics, assign the readings, and run the room.

01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Assignment	Percent of Final Grade
Attendance	25%
Discussion Board (before each class)	15%
Student Led Topics	9%
Surveys (3: intake, midterm, evaluation)	2%
Book Review (Slides + Presentation)	12%
Op-Ed Project (Draft + Review + Final)	20%
Group Policy Brief	17%

02 Due Dates

Assignment	Due Date
Discussion board post	9:00 a.m., each class day
Surveys (3)	August 26, October 7, final week
Op-ed, first draft	September 21
Op-ed peer review	September 24
Op-ed final draft	September 28
Book Review (slides)	November 23
Group Project	December 1/3
Group Project reflection	December 4

03 The Essentials

- **Before every class:** one short discussion-board post, due **9:00 a.m.**, in Canvas.
- **Attendance is 25%.** The first three absences cost almost nothing; four to six is where a semester goes wrong.
- **Late work** costs one point per hour, but never drops below 50% — with one exception: the **op-ed rough draft (September 21)** loses 10% immediately, then 1% per hour, with no floor and no exceptions, because two classmates are waiting on it.

- **Devices stay in bags.** Non-class use of a laptop or phone means being marked absent for that session.
- **Surveys** and their screenshot receipts run through **Canvas, under Assignments.**

04 The Full Syllabus

Everything else — the week-by-week schedule with all readings, assignment details, and every policy — lives in the full syllabus:

<https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-309/readme.html>